

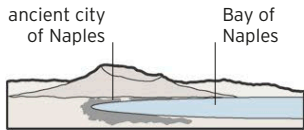
Vesuvius

Europe's most dangerous volcano, famous for its large historic eruptions, including the massive and deadly eruption of 79 CE

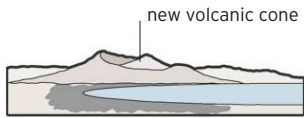


THE EVOLUTION OF VESUVIUS

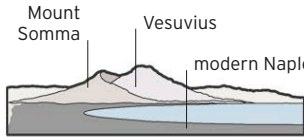
Before the eruption in 79 CE, Vesuvius was a single volcanic cone with a huge crater. Later, a new cone grew within this crater. Today, this new, much enlarged, cone is known as Vesuvius. Much of the older cone, now called Mount Somma, has eroded away.



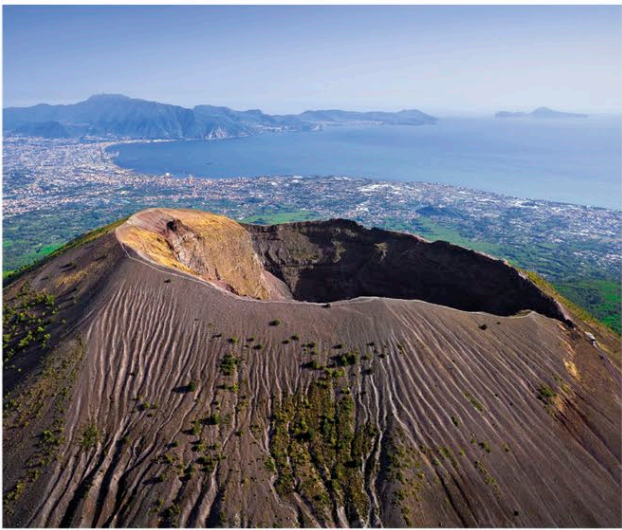
BEFORE 79CE ERUPTION



17TH-18TH CENTURY CE



TODAY

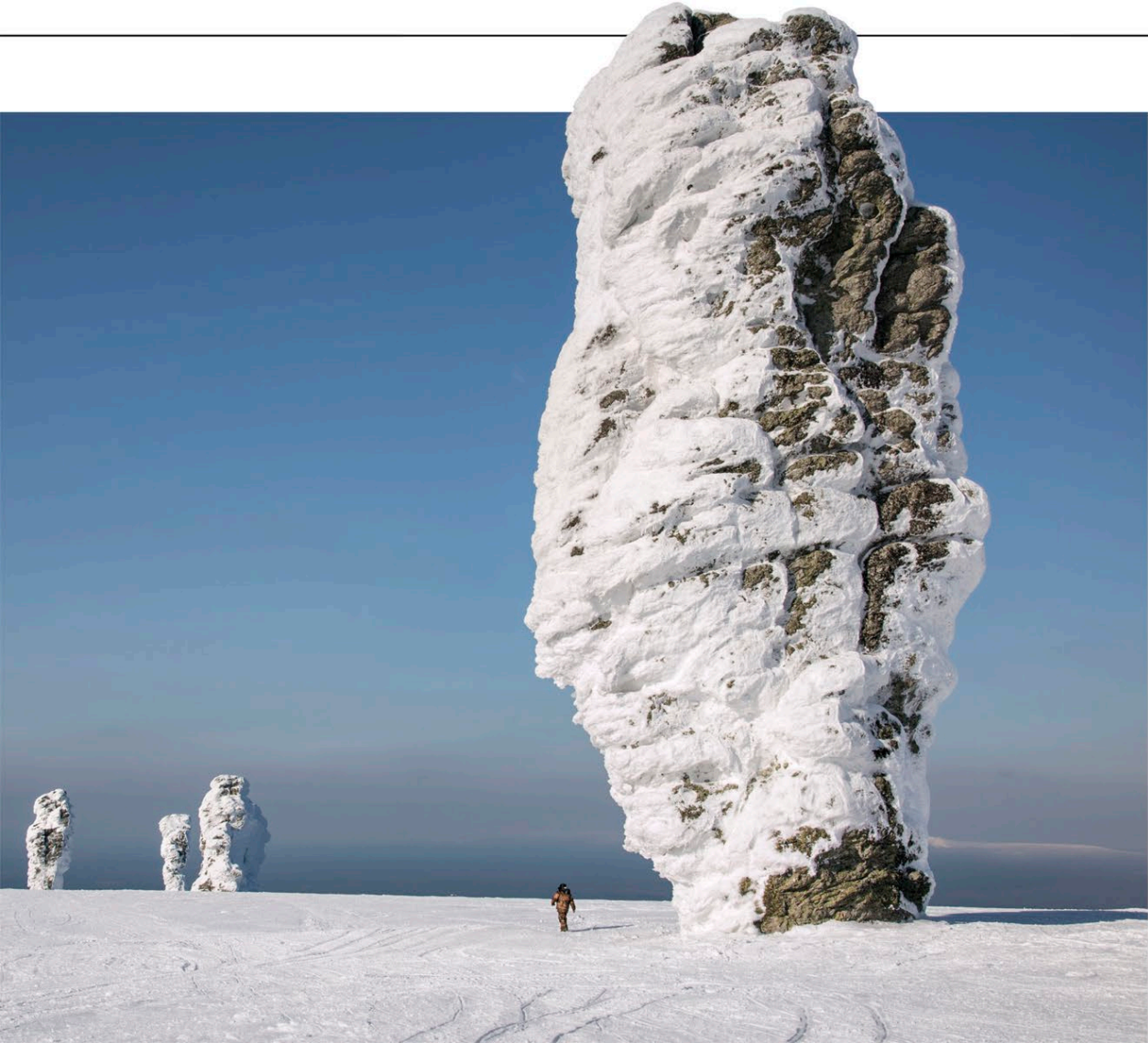


△ DECEPTIVE CALM
Vesuvius's 1,300-ft- (400-m-) wide summit crater is outlined here. Part of the Bay of Naples is visible in the background, with the island of Capri in the far distance.

Vesuvius is a stratovolcano that lies just 5 miles (8 km) away from the Italian city of Naples, in the most densely populated volcanic area in the world. Its location and its capacity for especially violent eruptions are what make it so dangerous. Vesuvius has a steep cone, with a height of 4,203 ft (1,281 m), and sits within the caldera of an older volcano called Mount Somma. Its lower slopes are dotted with villages and vineyards.

Destructive past

Of Vesuvius's numerous large historic eruptions, the most infamous occurred in 79 CE. During the explosion, falls of volcanic ash and pyroclastic surges buried the towns of Pompeii and Herculaneum, killing about 2,100 people. Another enormous volcanic blast in 1631 killed more than 3,000 people, while an eruption in 1906 killed more than 200. There has been no eruption since 1944, suggesting that a large explosion is overdue. Plans have been drawn up for an evacuation in the event of warning signs, such as increased seismic activity.



△ WINTER FOREST
A large part of the Urals is covered in taiga, the coniferous forest that stretches across northern Eurasia. In winter, much of the forest is snow-covered.

◁ ROCK GIANTS
Known as the Manupuner rocks, these stone pillars, more than 100 ft (30 m) high, jut out of a plateau in the western Urals. Legend has it that they were giants turned to stone by a shaman.